

Flashcards — Plain English, built around your 3 exam questions

Your oral has **3 questions**, **~4 min each**, and you only ever need: a clear opinion + a reason. This deck is grouped to match the exam:

- **Q1 — the modern hard cases (weeks 9–11):** nuclear, drones, killer robots. (*The big focus.*)
- **Q2 — the foundations (weeks 1–8):** can war be right, when you can start one, who you can kill, terrorism.
- **Q3 — synthesis:** take a foundation idea and apply it to a modern case.

No jargon needed. Cover the right column, say it in your own words, then check. The textbook words are parked in the last table if you ever want them.

START HERE — the master key (powers all 3 questions)

Get this and every question becomes the same move.

Question	Plain answer
The two basic ways to judge ANY action?	By results (did it do more good than harm?) or by rules (some things are just wrong, whatever the result).
Show both with a war example.	To end a war you could bomb a city of innocents. Results view: maybe okay — fewer deaths overall. Rules view: never — murdering innocents is always wrong.
Weakness of judging only by results?	It can excuse monstrous things (hurt one innocent to please many) — it has no "you must never."
Weakness of judging only by rules?	It can leave you doing nothing while a disaster unfolds, just to keep your own hands clean.
Meaning to cause a harm vs just knowing it'll happen?	Meaning it = it's your goal or your method. Knowing it = an unwanted side-effect. Most people think meaning it is far worse.
The two separate questions about ANY war?	(1) Was it right to start it? (2) Are they fighting it fairly? Judge each on its own — one can be yes and the other no.

Q2 PREP — Foundations (weeks 1–8)

What it asks: the basics — can war be justified, when, and what the limits are. **Example questions:** "Is the person who says morality doesn't apply to war right?" · "What's the strongest version of 'war is always wrong', and the best objection?" · "What makes someone a fair target?"

Question	Plain answer
Argument that morality doesn't apply to war?	War is about survival; fight nicely while the enemy doesn't and you lose — so anything goes.

Question	Plain answer
What's wrong with it?	If true, you couldn't call ANY atrocity wrong — only say you dislike it. But we clearly can say a massacre is truly wrong.
Argument that war is always wrong?	Killing is always wrong, and/or war's harm always outweighs its good.
Best comeback to "war is always wrong"?	Treating all killing as equally wrong blurs the line between killing an attacking soldier and murdering a baby — which can make atrocities easier to excuse, not harder.
The middle view the unit mostly uses?	War is sometimes okay, but only if it passes strict tests — both in why it's started and how it's fought.
Main accepted reason to start a war?	Self-defence — like a person fighting off an attacker, a country can defend itself against invasion.
Clever challenge to that?	A person defends their life; a country often defends its government or borders, not lives — so the comparison is shakier than it sounds.
Other checks before starting a war?	Is the reason genuine? More good than harm likely? A last resort? A real chance of success?
Invading to save people in another country — case FOR?	A country's right to be left alone shouldn't shield mass murder; outsiders may step in to protect people.
Case AGAINST?	"We're just helping" is easily an excuse for grabbing power, and these interventions often make things worse.
The most important rule once fighting starts?	Only deliberately attack fighters — never deliberately attack civilians.
Why are civilians off-limits (3 possible reasons)?	They're innocent, OR harmless, OR not responsible for the threat. ("Not responsible" is the strongest — plenty of civilians cheer the war on.)
What really makes someone a fair target?	A strong view: whether they're actually responsible for an unfair threat — not just whether they wear a uniform.
Can civilians ever die "okay-ly"?	Yes — if their deaths are an unwanted side-effect and not out of proportion to the gain. Deliberately killing them is never okay.
Catch with "I didn't mean to kill them"?	It can be a cop-out — you can't kill 50 civilians and shrug "didn't mean to." It must be genuinely unintended and proportionate.
What is terrorism, plainly?	Deliberately attacking innocent people to frighten or pressure a wider group.
Why is it wrong?	It breaks the biggest rule — targeting innocents on purpose.
Is terrorism always worse than war?	Not obviously — war kills innocents too. If we condemn terrorism for that, we should scrutinise "normal" wars that do the same.

Question	Plain answer
Can a government be a terrorist?	Yes — a state that deliberately terrorises innocents is doing terrorism too, not just rebels.
What does "an evil weapon" mean?	One that's wrong by its very nature, not just for the damage it does — like poison gas or torture.

Q1 PREP — The modern hard cases (weeks 9–11) ★

A whole question on its own, and the main focus. Three topics: nuclear, drones, killer robots.

Example questions: *"Are nuclear weapons evil in themselves?" · "Is a drone killing war or just execution?" · "Does it matter if a human or a machine kills you?"*

Nuclear weapons

Question	Plain answer
Why are nukes such a hard case?	A big nuke can't tell soldiers from civilians, can't be contained, and wipes out whole cities — it breaks every fair-fighting rule at once.
Are nukes "evil in themselves"?	Strong yes: you basically can't use a big one without massacring innocents, so it can never be used fairly.
The "threaten vs do" puzzle?	Keeping peace by threatening nuclear attack only works if you'd really do it — but really doing it is mass murder. So is it wrong even to threaten?
Why is that the "rules vs results" clash again?	Results: the threat kept the peace for decades, so it's fine. Rules: genuinely intending to murder millions is wrong, even if you never do it.
A surprising doubt?	Some argue nukes may not actually keep the peace, and that it wasn't the bomb that ended WWII — so even the "it works" defence is shaky.

Drones / targeted killing

Question	Plain answer
Basic worry about killing a chosen person by drone?	It often happens off the battlefield — so is it war (killing an enemy is allowed) or just execution with no trial?
The worst version ("signature strike")?	Killing someone for their behaviour pattern without knowing who they are — you may kill people you can't even identify.
The "zero risk" worry?	If you can kill with no danger to yourself, it stops being a fight and looks like hunting — and it makes starting wars too easy.
Case FOR drones?	Precise; can kill fewer civilians than invasions or carpet-bombing, and keeps your own people safe.
Case AGAINST drones?	The civilian deaths enrage whole populations and create more enemies than they remove — so they can backfire.

Killer robots (machines that choose who to kill)

Question	Plain answer
Killer robot vs drone?	A drone still has a human pulling the trigger; a killer robot picks and kills targets itself, with no human deciding.
The "no one's responsible" argument?	If a robot kills the wrong person, no one can fairly be blamed — not the programmer (couldn't predict it), the commander (didn't decide it), or the machine (can't be punished). A killing no one can answer for is wrong.
The "it's disrespectful" argument?	Being killed by a machine that "decided" to kill you treats your life as not mattering — no human ever weighed whether your death was justified.
Strongest argument FOR killer robots?	Machines don't panic, rage, or seek revenge — the things that make soldiers commit atrocities — so they might kill fewer innocents. Then refusing to build them would be the worse choice.
How does the other side answer that?	Even if robots killed fewer people, no one still answers for the mistakes and the killed are still treated as not mattering — fewer deaths doesn't fix those.
Why does this topic matter most?	It's the examiner's own field. The two arguments against (no one's responsible; it's disrespectful) are his; "they're safer" is the main reply pushing back.

Q3 PREP — Synthesis (link a foundation to a modern case)

*What it asks: take ONE idea from weeks 1–8 and apply it to nuclear/drones/robots. The trick: almost every link is the "rules vs results" clash in a new outfit. **Example questions:** "Does the 'accidental deaths can be okay' rule also excuse drone civilian deaths?" · "Could you defend keeping nukes to scare off attackers the way you'd defend any war for survival?" · "Can a machine ever follow the 'only attack fighters' rule?"*

Question	Plain answer
The one link behind most synthesis questions?	"Rules vs results." E.g. the nuclear "threaten-to-keep-the-peace" debate AND the killer-robot debate are both "save lives (results)" vs "some things are just wrong (rules)."
"Only attack fighters" applied to nukes?	A nuke can't aim at fighters only — so it breaks the rule by its very nature, not just by accident.
The "unwanted side-effect" rule applied to drones?	Are drone civilian deaths a genuine accident, or are signature strikes so reckless they don't really count as "unintended"?
"Only attack fighters" — nuke vs robot, which fails worse?	A nuke can't aim at all; a robot might aim but can't truly judge a messy situation. Both fail the rule, in different ways.

Question	Plain answer
Does "no risk to your side" link how-you-fight back to whether-to-start?	Yes — if your soldiers face no danger (drones/robots), starting a war gets too cheap, so a fighting-question bleeds into a starting-question.
Defend nuclear threats the way a "survival-first" person defends war?	A "survival is all that matters" person could defend nuclear threats; the rules person replies that survival can't justify a standing plan to murder millions.

■ The exam habit (use it on all 3 answers)

Question	Plain answer
The shape of a good answer?	Say what you think → one reason → the best argument against you → why you still hold it → one example.
What the marker most wants?	That you pick a side and give a reason. There's no "right" answer — a clear view with one reason beats sitting on the fence.
Rescue move if you're stuck?	Ask aloud: "Is this about whether it was right to start the war, or how it's being fought?" then "Does the results view or the rules view fit better here?"

■ (Optional) the proper words — only if a tutor uses them

You don't need these to understand anything above; they're just the textbook labels for the plain ideas.

Plain idea	Textbook word
judging by results	consequentialism / utilitarianism
judging by rules	deontology / absolutism
was it right to start a war	jus ad bellum
is it being fought fairly	jus in bello
only attack fighters, not civilians	distinction
harm not out of proportion to the gain	proportionality
evil in itself	mala in se
"an unwanted side-effect can be okay" rule	doctrine of double effect
who counts as a fair target	liability / moral equality of combatants
keeping peace by threatening attack	deterrence (a.k.a. "mutual assured destruction")
the examiner (killer robots is his field)	Robert Sparrow